

# ANNUAL REPORT

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# TABLE OF CONTENT



**01** Letter from the  
ED

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**02** Organisation  
Overview

---

**03** Executive  
Summary

---

**04** Performance  
Overview

---

**05** Performance  
Overview

---

**06** Success Story  
Spotlight

---

**07** Climate &  
Livelihood Impact

---

**08** From Change to  
Impact

---

**09** Future Outlook

---

**10** Contact  
Information

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# LETTER FROM EXECUTIVE DIRECTOR

## Denise Ayebare

ED- BETTERLIFE INTERNATIONAL

2025 has been a year that brought me back, again and again, to the reason BetterLife exists.

I have stood in places where climate change is not a conversation, but a condition people are forced to live through. I have met mothers who spend entire nights standing with their children because floods have taken their homes, and still wake up to try again. I have sat with young people in refugee settlements who are full of ideas, full of energy, but locked out of opportunity. And I have walked with farmers who are not failing because they are not working hard, but because the seasons they once understood no longer exist in the same way. This is the reality we are working in.

In 2025, BetterLife International reached over 112,000 people across Uganda, South Sudan, Tanzania, and Ghana. But beyond the numbers, we made a conscious decision to go deeper to focus on solutions that are not temporary, but ones that begin to shift the conditions people are living in.

Through the SMILES Livelihood Programme, we saw what happens when people are given a real chance. Young people started small businesses. Women came together and built support systems for each other.



Families that once depended on aid began to find their own footing again. It was not immediate, and it was not easy, but it was real. And in many ways, it was the beginning of something bigger.

At the same time, we expanded Soilla, because we understood that sometimes the biggest gap is not effort, but access. Farmers are doing everything they can, but without the right information, at the right time, they remain vulnerable. Through Soilla, we are starting to change that slowly, but meaningfully.

What continues to shape this work is how close we remain to the communities we serve. We do not work from a distance. We listen. We sit in the reality, even when it is uncomfortable. And we build solutions together. That is what makes this work different. We are still growing. We are still learning. But we are committed.

To our partners, to our supporters, and most importantly, to the communities we walk with thank you for trusting us. The challenges are real. But so are the people. And that is what keeps us going.

# ORGANISATION OVERVIEW



## → Vision

We envision a world where every person, regardless of their background, has the opportunity to live a fulfilling and sustainable life.

### Our Focus Areas

- Climate-Smart Agriculture
- Refugee & Host Community Livelihoods (SMILES Programme)
- Youth Leadership & Climate Action
- Digital Innovation (Soilla Platform)
- Environmental Sustainability & Circular Economy

## → Mission

To create a better life for everyone by promoting sustainable practices, empowering young people, supporting vulnerable groups, and fostering peace and equality in communities.

### Where We Work

- Uganda
- South Sudan
- Tanzania
- Ghana

# EXECUTIVE SUMMARY

In 2025, BetterLife International Organization marked a defining year of growth, transitioning from programme expansion to regional scale, systems strengthening, and institutional leadership. Building on the foundations established in previous years, the organization deepened its work across Uganda, South Sudan, Tanzania, and Ghana while expanding its influence within regional and global climate and development spaces.

Throughout the year, BetterLife focused on delivering integrated, community-driven solutions that address the interconnected challenges of climate change, food insecurity, and economic vulnerability. Particular emphasis was placed on strengthening refugee and host community livelihoods, advancing climate-smart agriculture, and scaling digital innovation through the Soilla platform.

In total, the organization reached over 112,430 beneficiaries, with women, youth, and displaced populations at the centre of all programming. This growth reflects not only an increase in reach, but also a shift toward more sustainable, systems-based interventions that deliver long-term impact.

## Beneficiaries reached



112,430

## Refugees & Host community



41,200

## Farmers supported



18,900



# PERFORMANCE OVERVIEW



## Organizational Context and Strategic Direction

The operational context in 2025 continued to be shaped by increasing climate variability, economic pressures, and displacement across the regions where BetterLife works. In Uganda and South Sudan, refugee populations remained particularly vulnerable to both environmental and socio-economic shocks. Across all countries of operation, smallholder farmers faced unpredictable weather patterns, reduced yields, and limited access to climate-informed agricultural support.

In response, BetterLife adopted a strategy focused on resilience, inclusion, and innovation, strengthening programmes that simultaneously address environmental sustainability and economic empowerment. This approach ensured that communities were not only supported to cope with immediate challenges, but also equipped with the tools and systems necessary to adapt and thrive in the long term.

## Youth Leadership and Climate Advocacy

Recognizing the critical role of young people in driving climate action, BetterLife continued to invest in youth leadership and advocacy programmes throughout 2025. Through structured training sessions, dialogues, and participation in national and international forums, young people were equipped with the skills and platforms needed to engage in climate policy and decision-making processes.

The organization facilitated over 60 youth dialogues and supported participation in major climate platforms, contributing to increased youth representation in climate governance spaces. These efforts ensured that the voices of young people, particularly those from vulnerable communities, were included in shaping climate solutions.



## Programme Performance and Impact

### Strengthening Refugee and Host Community Livelihoods – SMILES Programme

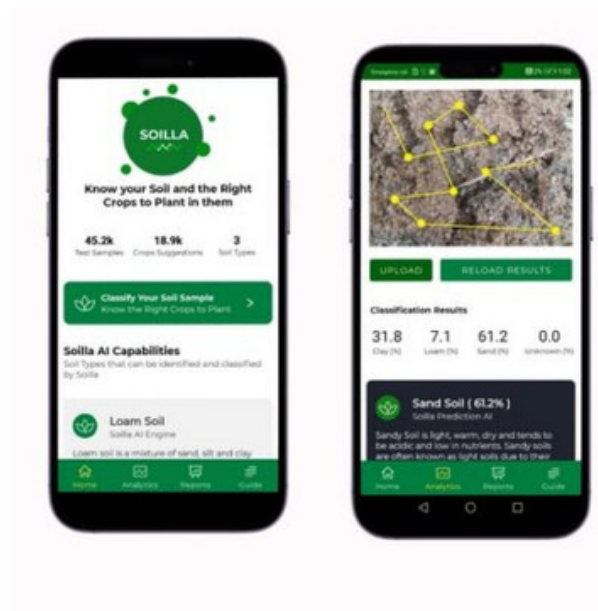
In 2025, the SMILES (Market Inclusive Livelihood Pathways to Self-Reliance) programme emerged as one of BetterLife's most impactful initiatives, significantly expanding its reach and depth across refugee settlements and host communities in Uganda and South Sudan.

Moving beyond traditional skills training models, the programme adopted a more comprehensive approach that integrates vocational training, enterprise development, financial literacy, and market access. This shift ensured that participants were not only equipped with skills but also supported to translate those skills into sustainable income-generating activities.



## Scaling Digital Agriculture – The Soilla Platform

In 2025, the Soilla Smart Agriculture Platform emerged as a leader in digital innovation for climate-smart agriculture through BetterLife. It addressed smallholder farmers' need for timely, accurate, and localized information, offering insights on soil health, crop selection, weather, and markets. The platform onboarded 18,900 farmers, processed over 3.6 million data points, and sent more than 420,000 tailored advisory messages. This resulted in a 37% increase in crop yields and a 28% reduction in input costs, enhancing decision-making and resource use. Soilla's expansion signifies a major technological advancement in community-based climate solutions, paving the way for regional growth.



# SUCCESS STORY SPOTLIGHT



## Refugee Entrepreneur

### Poultry Farmer

Before joining the SMILES Programme, Amina struggled to earn a stable income in Bidi Bidi refugee settlement. Through BetterLife's vocational training, she learned poultry farming and basic business skills. With support and mentorship, she started a small poultry business.

Today, she earns a steady income, supports her family, and participates in a savings group. Her journey reflects how the SMILES Programme helps refugee and host community members build sustainable livelihoods and regain economic independence.



## Smallholder Farmer

### Maize & Bean Farmer

John, a smallholder farmer in eastern Uganda, faced low yields due to poor soil management and unpredictable weather. After joining the Soilla platform, he received soil testing support and regular advisory messages on planting and crop management.

By applying these recommendations, John improved his harvest and reduced farming losses. He now produces more food for his family and earns additional income, demonstrating how digital agriculture can strengthen resilience among smallholder farmers.

# CLIMATE & LIVELIHOOD IMPACT



In 2025, BetterLife International focused on delivering integrated solutions that address both environmental sustainability and economic empowerment across Uganda, South Sudan, Tanzania, and Ghana. Our programmes supported farmers, youth, and refugee communities through climate-smart agriculture, digital innovation, and livelihood development initiatives. Through the SMILES Programme, vulnerable populations were equipped with practical skills and supported to establish small businesses, enabling them to generate income and improve household stability. At the same time, the expansion of the Soilla platform allowed farmers to access critical agricultural information, improving productivity and strengthening resilience to climate variability.

Our environmental efforts continued through community-based recycling initiatives and sustainable farming practices, reducing environmental degradation while creating opportunities for local income generation. Across all programmes, we prioritized community participation, ensuring that solutions were locally driven and sustainable beyond project implementation. By combining climate action with livelihood support, BetterLife International continues to build systems that not only respond to immediate needs but also strengthen long-term resilience and economic independence for vulnerable communities.

# FROM CHALLENGE TO CHANGE

Across the communities we serve, climate change, displacement, and limited economic opportunities continue to shape daily life. In 2025, BetterLife International focused on turning these challenges into practical, community-driven solutions.

## The Challenge

Farmers faced unpredictable rainfall, poor soil conditions, and declining yields. Refugee and host communities struggled with limited access to stable income, while young people lacked opportunities to contribute meaningfully to their communities.

## What We Did

We provided hands-on training, introduced digital agriculture through the Soilla platform, supported small businesses through the SMILES programme, and engaged youth in climate action. Our approach combined skills, technology, and community support systems.

## The Change

Farmers improved productivity and reduced losses. Refugees and host communities established small businesses and increased incomes. Young people became active leaders in climate action, driving change within their communities.



## Why It Matters

Our work is helping communities move from vulnerability to resilience not just by addressing immediate needs, but by building systems that support long-term sustainability and economic independence.

# FUTURE OUTLOOK

BetterLife International continues to strengthen climate resilience and inclusive livelihoods across vulnerable communities by expanding practical, community-driven solutions that address both environmental and economic challenges. Through the growth of the SMILES Programme and the scale-up of the Soilla platform, the organization is supporting farmers, youth, and refugee populations with the skills, tools, and opportunities needed to build sustainable futures. By investing in innovation, strengthening partnerships, and empowering local communities, BetterLife is creating pathways for long-term resilience, improved food security, and economic independence across the regions in which it operates.



## → Future Plan

BetterLife International aims to expand its climate resilience and livelihood programmes by scaling the SMILES initiative and strengthening the Soilla platform across more communities and regions. The organization will continue to invest in practical solutions that support farmers, youth, and refugee populations through skills development, digital innovation, and community-based systems. By strengthening partnerships, improving programme delivery, and enhancing monitoring and learning systems, BetterLife seeks to increase its impact while ensuring long-term sustainability. These efforts will contribute to building resilient communities that are better equipped to adapt to climate challenges and create sustainable economic opportunities.

## → Innovation

BetterLife International will focus on strengthening regional coordination and expanding its presence into new communities through scalable, locally led programmes. The organization will invest in building stronger community institutions, supporting cooperative systems, and enhancing access to markets for small enterprises. Efforts will also be directed toward strengthening youth-led innovation and increasing opportunities for women in climate and livelihood initiatives. By deepening collaboration with governments and partners, BetterLife aims to create more inclusive systems that support long-term growth, resilience, and shared economic progress across the communities it serves.



# Thank You

At BetterLife International Organization, we are committed to building partnerships that drive sustainable impact across communities. Our work continues to expand across Uganda, South Sudan, Tanzania, and Ghana, focusing on climate resilience, livelihood development, and youth empowerment. We welcome collaboration with partners, donors, institutions, and individuals who share our vision of creating resilient communities and sustainable futures.

## Get in Touch

Whether you are interested in partnerships, funding opportunities, or learning more about our programmes, we would be pleased to hear from you.

Together, we can create lasting impact.

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